could resolve among themselves. Accordingly, President Premadasa, who had succeeded President Jayawardene, requested the withdrawal of all Indian troops. This request had to be acceded to as per the terms of the agreement and the IPKF started to fall back from early 1990 onwards. This rearguard action, while technically still at war with the LTTE, was no mean feat, with the LTTE rushing in to occupy the areas being vacated by the IPKF. The last unit to leave Sri Lanka was Lucky Seven on 30 March 1990, and the photos of our gallant Khalsas were everywhere, splashed across the pages of numerous periodicals. India lost close to 1200 personnel, killed in Op Pawan and a memorial to them exists at Sri Jayewardenepura Kotte on the outskirts of Colombo, which was built in 2008. The names of the 1200 soldiers who died are inscribed on black marble along the four sides of the memorial, and I laid a wreath there when I visited Sri Lanka as the COAS in October 2021. No sooner had the IPKF withdrawn than the LTTE reneged on all their promises and civil war broke out all over again. The Indian intervention from 1987 to 1990 had achieved nothing at all. The civil war in Sri Lanka was to continue for another two decades, till the capture and death of the LTTE supremo and founder, Vellupillai Prabhakaran, in May 2009.

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